

Hold up. The fact that Tyler’s lease was about to expire should have had nothing to do with his decision of when and how to purchase his first property. Instead, he should have created a situation in which *he* was in control of the timeline.

The easy solution in this scenario would have been to go on a month-to-month lease. It might sound crazy and expensive, but too many people make the mistake of timing a home purchase around another life deadline—like moving to a new city, selling a previous home, or getting married.

Remember, Tyler is making a choice that’s easily worth more than \$300,000. Small mistakes or hasty decisions can have five-figure consequences in the immediate future and even more significant consequences over time. Rushing due to an artificial timeline can incur multiple unnoticeable “soft” costs, like offering a few thousand dollars more than necessary in order to submit a winning bid on a house.

Instead, Tyler needs to sit back, relax, and ask his landlord for a month-to-month extension on his lease. Landlords will almost always agree to this—for a small increase in rent, of course, but nothing so large that it outweighs the cost of potential hasty home buyer mistakes. Even if Tyler’s rent increases \$200 per month, that would cost a total of \$2,400 per year, which pales in comparison to that \$300,000 price tag. Plus, he probably won’t need a whole year to purchase his new home.

Life events shouldn’t affect your purchase decision. Always create a timeline where you are in command. While it won’t guarantee you a good deal, it will certainly help you avoid a bad one.

KNOW WHAT YOU WANT

After driving around a few neighborhoods and keeping a diligent eye on listing platforms like Zillow, Redfin, and the MLS (which you can access through a real estate agent) you should start to form an understanding whether the types of properties you want to buy—and those that meet your financial goals—actually exist. It’s your job, not your real estate agent’s, to determine what you want and whether those wants are realistic.

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